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It was the best of years and the worst of years. A thrilling and, towards the end, frightening roller coaster for politicians, businessmen and ordinary Indians alike.

SHIPRA DAS



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Primed POLITICIAN **Manmohan Singh**

It was a year of revelation. India discovered the politician in the prime minister, and Manmohan Singh his inner voice to exercise the power of the Prime Minister's Office. When anointed, Manmohan was to be the CEO who would run the Government and Sonia Gandhi, as UPA chairperson, was to manage the allies, the minority shareholders. The Left was to provide political ballast and independent scrutiny. As India hurtles towards elections, the rear view mirror shows the distance between intent and reality. For 48 months, the prime minister was hostage to the antics of his Cabinet whom he could not choose and to the ideological intransigence of the Left. Policy decisions were held to ransom at 175 GoMs by vested interest groups. His frequent exhortations of "the Government must..." almost vindicated his status as an outsider in politics.

The economy was too shallow and needed reforms to spur demand to sustain growth. National security called for urgent attention. Yet, political procrastination was the preferred option and national interest was mortgaged to ensure political survival. As a tired people cried for redemption, the reluctant ruler unexpectedly exercised his authority. Echoing the battle cry of Guru Gobind Singh, he forced the coalition to dump the Left and save the Indo-US nuclear deal. The flash of authority was what the middle class expected of the prime minister. But destiny left little room for him to savour the 'Singh is King' chorus. As the global meltdown threatens jobs and terrorists defy the state, Manmohan faces both a challenge and an opportunity. While India awaits redemption, he has taken charge of the war room for economic resurgence and patriotic pride. How he converts the toxic challenge will determine if his will be a lasting or subprime legacy.

by Shankkar Aiyar